

Chapter 1: Conductive Reasoning

The second ring of the facility was unusually quiet — just the low, rhythmic hum of overhead fluorescents and the faint echo of someone vaulting something three rooms over. Herman didn't care. He had more pressing problems. Namely, the flailing cop draped over one shoulder, and the freshly sabotaged hook directly in his path.

The hook had clattered to the ground just as the Doctor rounded the corner, Leon kicking and struggling wildly on his shoulder. He had finally started to come around fully from the baton strike that set him prone and was now well on his way to breaking Herman's grip on his waistline. Jake had just finished dismantling it — fast fingers, smug grin — and the nuisance flipped Herman off before vanishing down a side hallway, feet barely touching the tile, content to make the Doctor's job as difficult as physically possible.

"Great," Herman muttered, voice thick with irritation and exhaustion. "Just great."

Herman exhaled slowly through his teeth and adjusted his grip as Leon squirmed again, staggering slightly to the side as a knee almost hit his head, and surveyed the area. The next closest hook was too far off, and the basement with its indestructible hook quartet was clearly out of range. But this particular survivor was one of *those*. Not fast. Not loud. Not even slippery. Just — gone, the second he got loose. A ghost in denim and bruises. He did not have the patience to track him down yet again before the gates could release him back to the Fog. The Entity was annoyed enough with how often survivors escaped lately. It wouldn't serve him to let this one loose in the halls.

Herman ripped Leon, still flailing, from his shoulder and threw him at a locker. He hit the edge of the wood with a sharp crack, the impact knocking the wind from him and kicking the door open to catch him a second time on the way down. Dazed, Leon rolled onto his back, trying to refocus his eyes before finding himself being hoisted up again.

"Nothing personal, Mr. Kennedy. I would have preferred to use a basement hook and be done with this chase. But you seem particularly animated today and I am not in the mood to roll an ankle on the steps with your wriggling about."

He navigated into a nearby room, dumping Leon heavily against the cabinets on one wall. Old carts littered the space — rusted gurneys with half-locked wheels, trays with upturned pans, a few overturned IV poles resting like skeletal limbs along the walls. The air stank faintly of dust and ozone, like a place struck by lightning long ago and left to

rot. It would serve perfectly to keep this particular migraine contained for the time being, he mused to himself as he crouched to rummage through the pouches at the man's waist. The pest always had some kind of random item on hand that the Entity hadn't deemed important enough to remove; and sure enough, in one of the stained and battered hip pouches, he found a set of bright silver handcuffs. These soldier types were always so predictable. Real steel, not prop bullshit. The Entity must've let them pass without flagging their intent. Or maybe she just liked what they could do when repurposed.

"You have a nasty habit of vanishing into the dust when I stop looking, and I have a quota to fill today. Therefore, you are going to wait right here until I can locate your little saboteur friend and ensure that he can no longer disable the tools I require to do my job."

A painful wrenching tug on his shoulder to pull him to his feet, and a sharp click, and Leon was secured to a padlocked cabinet by one wrist. He winced against the strain on his shoulder, pulling himself into a heavy lean against the cabinet and trying to shake off the gray at the edges of his vision from the earlier impact.

Herman frowned slightly at the glassy expression in Leon's eyes and briefly touched his baton to the cabinet.

CRACK.

The charge arced through the cabinet and into the cuff in an instant. Leon *jolted* — back arching, breath catching in his throat like it had been yanked by force. A small sound escaped him — half growl, half gasp — and then he sagged again, panting. Wide-eyed. Awake.

Much better.

"Rise and shine, Mr. Kennedy. The Entity prefers her meals still screaming, afterall. It won't do for you to be too concussed to appreciate her attention, now, would it? Now if you'll excuse me, I have a pest to find. Once I locate him, I'll be sure to bring him here so I can fry him personally at your feet for the grievous insult of interfering with my work. Then we can resume from where we left off. Don't go anywhere, now!"

And with that, the Doctor stormed out of the room to continue his hunt, his manic giggle floating down the hallway with the diminishing terror radius, leaving Leon dazed and tugging at his own cuffs as they dug angry red marks into his wrist. He let out a hiss as

the motion pulled too fast, too far, the shoulder lighting up in protest. Not dislocated, but close enough to threaten it if he got clever.

The wrist burned.

It wasn't the surface sting — he'd felt that before. From tasers, from volts, from the Doctor's regular blasts — it was *deeper*. An ache curling through tendon and bone, buzzing in the socket of his shoulder. Leon blinked hard, the afterimage of that electric snap still painting sharp edges behind his eyelids. The world tilted, but settled.

"Ok, less than ideal..."

Leon twisted at the cuff experimentally.

Nothing.

No give in the chain, no flex in the cabinet.

He patted down pockets, flipping open his pouches and pulling random bits of junk from inside. Small rocks for distracting, pens, an empty pepper spray bottle, spare roll of bandages... nothing particularly useful. More importantly, no keys. Tried the back pocket. His belt loops. Under the radio clip. Still nothing.

It seemed Herman had pocketed his cuff keys while searching him. Fantastic.

"Of course he did," Leon muttered under his breath, voice dry. "Why wouldn't he?"

Glancing around the room didn't offer anything much to help either. Trays stacked in one corner, two overturned gurneys, an IV pole across the floor like a tripping hazard that never got cleaned up. Lots of metal, but anything sharp or sturdy enough to pry with was too far away to test out.

He reached out, more careful this time, fingers sweeping what debris was within arm's length. A toppled tray. The edge of an overturned gurney. Something that might've once been a pen but was now too bent to be useful. Not even so much as a staple or paperclip to pick the lock with, not that he had ever been really good at it. That was more Jill's specialty from what the others had told him.

"Looks like I'm waiting, then. Damnit. Just had to get the one guy who is willing to improvise."

He leaned his head back against the metal, rubbing at his wrenched shoulder with his free hand, and closed his eyes. Just for a second. Just to think.

Not like he was going anywhere.

The cuff rattled sharply as Leon pulled against the chain, testing for any give. The cabinet creaked, but didn't budge.

"C'mon," he growled under his breath, planting his boots and bracing into the motion. The metal groaned again, louder this time, but still held firm.

Another tug. Another ache in his wrist.
Still no movement.

In the distance, he could pick up the sounds of the others moving quickly around the building. The Doctor's thudding steps were easy enough to pick up even without the weird aura field that set his heart hammering in his head, and the speed of the smaller scuffling steps told him that a chase was on nearby.

Fast.
Light.
Meg, maybe?

Not likely Jake either way. Good. With how annoyed the Doctor was at Jake right now, he might decide to get creative there too. Best to let him take out his frustration on some normal hook kills. Unpleasant, but at least everyone knew what to expect. Sharp stab, a brief moment of terror, then back to the campfire to rest. Not too terrible in the long run.

He stilled for a moment, listening. The uneven echo of sprinting feet. The skittering scrape of something being vaulted. Then that familiar electric crackle in the air — a rising static hum that meant only one thing:

Herman had eyes on them.

The air shifted, sharp and metallic. Leon stiffened. He'd felt that before. The lead-up to one of the Doctor's area-wide shocks — a burst meant to disorient, slow reaction times, force mistakes. Of course, he would be trying to slow the survivor down, scramble them just enough to confuse movement. It always stung, and everyone had long since learned the taste in the air that preceded it.

The shock wave passed easily through the far wall, sparks dancing in white arcs from corner to corner. He followed the flickers with his eyes — arcs of energy crawling across desk legs, chair frames, handles. Everything metal.

Metal.

His eyes locked on the metal cuff. The realization hit him a breath too late.

The shockwave hit the filing cabinet like lightning striking a weathervane. The pain was instant, blinding, slicing through the cuff and across his bones, discharging across flesh and muscle alike. Every nerve lit up like copper wire in a furnace. His scream tangled in his throat as his knees buckled, limbs locking against the intrusion in violent lurches. His hip slammed against the cabinet on the way back to the floor, and for one breathless second, he hung there — suspended by his arm, muscles locked, nerves screaming.

He gasped sharply as the chase passed by, then choked on the tail end of it, body twitching as the last of the voltage bled out through him, leaving him gasping and grasping at the cement of the floor as if it could somehow anchor his nerves back in place.

He didn't remember falling.

Only the pain. And the taste of metal in the back of his throat.

His arm was stretched painfully above him, cuffed wrist still locked to the cabinet. His body had collapsed at an angle — one hip on the floor, the other twisted awkwardly against the base of the unit. His legs shook beneath him, muscles twitching from the aftershock.

The room smelled like burnt ozone now. Like the air just after a lightning strike.

Leon stayed down for a while, breathing through clenched teeth, trying to will his nerves into compliance.

Eventually, the tremors softened enough to let him sit up straighter. Leon pressed his back to the cabinet, breath hitching as he tried to ease the strain from his arm. The muscles in his shoulder burned from the jolt. Every nerve felt skinned raw, still catching echoes of the voltage that had torn through him. His fingers were numb. The cuff bit deep into raw skin.

He took another look around the room, a horrified understanding slowly coming to the surface.

It wasn't just cluttered.
It was *loaded*.

Metal trays. Surgical carts. Gurneys with chrome legs. Even the cabinet he was chained to had rivets and handles begging to carry current. Every piece of furniture in here had a conductive surface. The static had nowhere else to go but through the one organic thing grounded in the room.

And this room?
It was in the middle of *everything*.

He knew this layout well. There were at least *three* generators within range of this hallway. Half the damned trial route ran straight past this door. And every time Herman used his static field to slow someone down, the blast would pass through the walls, seek out the nearest conductors...

And arc *right into him*.

Not on purpose.
Not even malicious.
Just... **collateral**.

Leon stared up at his cuffed wrist. The skin was already red, edges ringed with angry indentations.

The others had no idea.

Oh God.

Every single time they passed through in chase... it would happen *again*.

They would have no choice but to keep coming back. And he would have no choice but to keep taking it.

".... Shit."

Chapter 2: Short Circuit

Jake crouched low behind a cracked vinyl privacy screen, its peeling edge pressed against his shoulder as he tried to stay perfectly still. The footsteps were close — not quite sprinting, but fast enough to signal active chase. Somewhere nearby, a generator had blown — he'd heard it not long ago, a sharp burst and the whine of overtaxed wires. The hallway had lit briefly with the hum of a static surge. A wide-area pulse. The jolt had dropped him into a dream of white noise and warped faces — the floor writhing beneath him like something alive, muscles twitching out of sequence for minutes after. He'd woken up behind a generator he didn't remember fixing, pulse hammering in time with a memory he couldn't name.

He wasn't keen on doing that again anytime soon.

He pressed one hand to the floor to steady himself, heart beating too loud in his ears. He felt it in his teeth before he felt it in his skin — the telltale buzz of an incoming shock. It gathered pressure like a weather front, a phantom weight that prickled across the back of his neck and tightened the tendons in his forearms. It felt fainter than the last few times he had been shocked today. Hopefully, he was far enough out of range to not get more than a passing numbness this time. It was never overly debilitating, but the random hallucinations and muscle twinges were something he could really do without. He flexed his fingers, checking for tremors. Still there — faint, but present. Just enough to make clipping a wire a pain in the ass.

"Just once," he muttered to himself, "I'd like to have a normal goddamn trial without getting brain-fried before I even find a teammate."

From somewhere down the hall came a startled cry — high-pitched, unmistakably Meg — and Jake tensed, waiting for the telltale thud of a hit or the snap of a pallet drop. Either one would let him know what direction they were looping in so he wouldn't have to come out of hiding so soon. No point getting zapped for a moral support cameo. He'd seen her tank worse hits and walk it off. And if it was just a standard burst, she'd be fine. Shaken, maybe, but still mobile.

The air buzzed again with a second charge building. Jake barely had time to suck in a breath before something new reached his ears — a voice, muffled, but urgent enough to raise every hair on his neck.

"Wait - DON'T..."

The shockwave rippled through the air, a low static buzz that flared briefly across the space. A single spark cracked off the edge of the privacy screen, catching Jake on the arm. He let out a sharp hiss, jerking away from the contact.

“Damn it—” he muttered, rubbing the angry red mark where the spark had connected with skin.

The scream that followed made him pause in confusion. It had layers — a secondary pitch, deeper, more ragged. Not fear. Not panic. Just raw pain. Jake’s brow furrowed. That wasn’t Meg. Someone else had gotten caught in the blast.

If he didn’t know better, he’d think someone got hit trying to talk Herman down or something. Unless you were right up against it, the shocks only messed with your mind and nerves. They didn’t really *hurt*. For someone to sound like they were in that much pain from a static blast, they would have needed to be practically touching the Doctor.

Who else was with them, anyways? He remembered Herman carrying someone when he’d pulled that earlier sabotage, but hadn’t gotten a good look. Whoever it was hadn’t been screaming at the time — just flailing — so he’d assumed they’d sort themselves out or recover once the hook was back.

Regardless, it would have been a stupid move, really. The Doctor wasn’t one of the killers who could be reasoned with. He took his job seriously and with a delight that bordered on mania some days. But that second scream — that yelp — landed wrong. It didn’t echo forward. It set the hairs on the back of Jake’s neck prickling, an unease sitting heavy in his stomach.

It had sounded like it came from behind the wall at his back.

The room at his back didn’t have a generator in it. No totem. No chest. Nothing useful. Just junk furniture, broken trays, the kind of clutter the Fog dumped in rooms to fill space. He’d passed through it earlier with barely a glance. It wasn’t even a particularly good hiding spot.

So why the hell would anyone be in there? Did something get added in that he missed?

The chaos outside eventually pulled away, the chase bleeding into another corner of the complex. Jake stood slowly, ears straining, and caught the tail end of a broken voice, exhausted and angry, from behind the wall.

“Fucking hell. Can I just — breathe — for two seconds?”

Jake’s brow furrowed. He placed a palm against the cool tile, tracing his way silently around the corner until he reached the doorframe of the adjacent room. Eyes scanning instinctively. Still no objectives. Still nothing but overturned carts and scattered debris. Which made the figure slumped against the far cabinet in a battered mess of RPD blue even more out of place.

Jake whistled low under his breath and stepped in, eyes scanning the setup. Leon was cuffed at the wrist — arm stretched uncomfortably above his head, body half-curved beneath it like he’d dropped mid-spasm. His shoulder looked angry. Raw tension threaded through the entire arm.

“Jesus, man,” Jake muttered. “You look like shit.”

Leon grunted in response, shifting his weight to pull himself off the floor, leaning heavily against the cabinet as he tried taking the weight off his shoulder. “Don’t sugarcoat it.”

Jake crossed the room in three strides, crouching to examine the cuff. “What the hell happened to you?”

Leon exhaled a humorless laugh and rattled the cuff lightly. “Apparently, my hiding skills got me promoted from gen jockey. Welcome to my new desk job.”

Jake tugged at the metal, bracing one foot on the cabinet as he tried to get the chain to snap. It creaked lightly against the cabinet handle, but didn’t budge.

“You’ve gotta be kidding me. He cuffed you to a freaking filing cabinet?”

“Didn’t even get a chair. The working conditions here suck.”

“Don’t you guys usually have keys for these things?”

Leon pushed his bangs back with one hand, yanking the cuff sharply in irritation and wincing as it bit into him again.

“Pretty sure the Doctor pocketed them while he was searching me. I was a little... *out of it.*” He gestured vaguely toward the wall with his free hand. “Didn’t exactly get the luxury of staying conscious through most of the decision-making process.”

Jake huffed through his nose. “Well, that’s comforting.”

He reached for the screwdriver clipped to his belt and wedged the flat end into the hinge between the cuff and the cabinet. The metal resisted, but he leaned in harder, tongue between his teeth, working the angle. It wasn't the cleanest method, but maybe if he could just pry the lip—

Leon's body jerked suddenly beside him.

"Hold on — don't—"

The air had shifted again — that metallic taste returned — and in the moment, Jake had completely missed it. Leon surged forward, shoving Jake back with his free just as the cabinet lit up like a bug zapper. Electricity danced along the edges, funnelled straight through the cuff and into Leon's arm. He arched violently, mouth open in a scream that caught midway, choking on itself as his body seized and bucked against the restraint.

Jake hit the floor with a hard thud, palms scraping against the tile. His screwdriver skittered off to the side, spinning once before vanishing beneath a rusted gurney.

"*Shit*—" He twisted, scrambling to push upright just in time to see Leon slam against the cabinet, back arching, head snapping back.

The sparks died off, and for a moment, all Jake could do was *stare*.

Leon sagged forward, the cuff dragging taut as he crumpled, then steadied himself with one trembling arm. His eyes were open — unfocused, distant, breath caught somewhere between a gasp and a choke. One hand curled against his vest, nails biting fabric as he struggled to ride out the recoil.

"Leon?"

No answer.

Jake took a step forward.

Leon lifted a shaky hand — not up, but out. Just a small wave. A breathless "wait." A hold.

Jake froze.

Leon knelt fully, head bowed, breathing shallow and quick. His shoulders rocked faintly with the rhythm of his pulse. After a few moments, he dropped back against the cabinet again, letting the cuff yank taut above him with a hiss.

“...What *the fuck* was that?” Jake asked, quieter now. Almost like the walls might answer.

Jake’s eyes traced the line between Leon’s arm and the cuffs, up through the metal cabinet, and around the room. Sparks still popped gently between pieces of furniture across the room, like static creeping along a thundercloud’s edge. Jake followed the line — from one overturned tray to a chrome IV stand, then up the cabinet where Leon’s arm trembled just shy of collapse.

“Holy shit, it’s focusing the static blasts, isn’t it?”

“Yeah,” Leon rasped, settling himself off his knees and sitting back against the cabinet,

“Yeah, I may have noticed.”

“You were trying to tell the others not to bring the chase down this way. That’s what I heard earlier.” Leon’s head thunked against the cabinet as he panted.

“It’d be nice if I could get a warning out before the world goes white again. They’re moving around so fast... there’s no time.”

“There’re easily 3 generators within radius of here, too. Fucking hell...”

Leon nodded, eyes distant. Jake was catching up fast, drawing the same conclusion. Even if they managed to warn the others off, eventually they would HAVE to come back this way. There was simply no avoiding it. Jake idly fiddled with his toolbelt, trying to think of a plan.

“There’s gotta be a way to break this.” He crouched beside the cuff again, eyeing the hinge. “I’ve pried a lock off a hook tower before. This is just... smaller.” He flexed his hand, already tingling from the earlier zap. “If I had something better than a screwdriver—”

His breath caught.

The hook.

His mind skipped back — to the moment in the hallway. The sabotaged hook. The thrashing figure on Herman’s shoulder. He hadn’t known who it was. Hadn’t stopped to check.

“*Fuck*,” Jake whispered. “That was you. I—” He stood up fast, hands bracing on his head. “If I hadn’t—shit—if I hadn’t taken that hook down—”

Leon waved him off dismissively.

“Don’t waste time feeling bad about something that worked. It slowed him down, gave you space. He just got creative. Guilt won’t help us now.”

“...But —”

“It was the right call in the moment. Seriously. I would have done the same. What we need now is some way to break these off.”

Jake swallowed the guilt back and tried to focus. He was right. It wasn’t serving anyone right now. He could warn the others to avoid the hallway for now, but they would eventually run out of further generators to work on, and most of the good loops and escape routes came straight through the area. Even if they managed to get it all done, there was no way for Leon to get out of the end gate short of breaking those stupid cuffs off, or else wait for Herman to send him back through the Fog the old-fashioned way. And with how badly those static blasts were being focused and funneled through the furniture, there was no guarantee what shape he’d even be in at that point.

So, it would have to be a tool hunt, then. Though with all the random toolboxes in this place that he had found over the trials, Jake had never once seen something actually **USEFUL** for something like this. No crowbars. No wire cutters. Not even a broken scalpel. The Entity didn’t leave them with what they *needed*. Just what she *thought* might be entertaining.

“Of course she wouldn’t,” he muttered. “Not her style. Flashlights that barely work, medkits that run out before you stop bleeding, but the second you need something *practical*—”

Both men seemed to come to the same conclusion, shared across a look.

They needed the keys.

Jake looked at the door. Then at Leon.

“I’ll find them.”

Leon managed a faint smirk — but it faded quickly, buried under the tension winding back into his shoulders. He nodded, closed his eyes, and waited for the air to shift again, tracking Jake's footfalls until they faded down the hallway.

Chapter 3: Conductive Reasoning

Jake had stopped checking his surroundings three drawers ago. Probably not the best call, all things considered. But after the fifth tray of shattered glass and bent syringes, the paranoia had dulled into background noise. Every cabinet, cart, and table in this wing had offered nothing but rusted scalpels, cracked syringes, and bandage rolls that

looked like they'd been soaked in something *before* the Fog found them. It wasn't even creepy anymore. Just tedious. Nothing had jumped him yet, and if Herman was still busy lighting up the far end of the map, that bought him time. Not comfort. Just time.

He slammed another drawer shut, the metal shrieking in protest, and ripped open the next one. More gauze. Rusted scalpels tangled like brittle weeds. A blood pressure cuff half-melted to the lining.

"*They're just keys*," he muttered, rifling with increasing irritation. "How hard is it to find a set of *fucking keys*? What are they, an inch wide? Half an inch? What, do they disintegrate if you make eye contact with them?"

The next drawer had old notebooks — pages torn and curling with moisture, most of the ink blurred beyond recognition. He flipped one open on reflex. Mold across the spine. The few pages still intact were stained with dark splashes that could've been ink. Could've been blood. Hard to tell anymore. Everything the Fog touched decayed in stages. Wood splintered. Paper decayed. Even metal rusted faster than it had any right to.

He tossed it aside and turned to the next tray when a scream knifed through the walls.

He froze.

One clean rip of pain, sharp enough to echo down through the vents. He crouched instinctively, angling himself toward the hallway's edge and holding still.

Leon.

The lights above him buzzed faintly, a flicker of static skipping down the line like a warning. No footsteps followed. No voices. Just the distant groan of the building settling in its chains, and the faint crackle of static in the overhead lights.

Jake exhaled slow through his nose, grounding himself with a palm against the floor. A single jolt like that wasn't part of a chase. That meant Herman was still near Leon — and nowhere near here.

He rubbed a hand down his face and stood. If Leon was still screaming, it meant he was still *alive*. If he was alive, Jake still had time.

And he wasn't wasting it.

Jake spotted Meg two rooms over, crouched beside a battered generator that was audibly wheezing under the strain of whatever makeshift repairs she was forcing on it. Her sleeves were rolled up past her elbows, grease smudged along one cheek, fingers working fast inside the open panel. She didn't even look up.

He approached slowly, boots scuffing tile just loud enough to not startle — or so he thought. The second his hand touched her shoulder, she jolted like he'd set her on fire.

"Shit—!" Meg yelped, slapping a live wire aside just before it could spark against the casing. "*What?! What could you POSSIBLY want that needs scaring a person so bad?!*"

Jake held up both hands, voice low. "We have a problem."

Meg glared, but stilled.

"The Doctor has Leon locked down in one of the rooms near the main gen cluster," he said quietly. "I need you to stay clear of that entire side of the building."

She blinked once, then rolled her eyes and dove back into the wires.

"You'd have me leave that bastard a *perfect* patrol path when we're this close to done?" she snapped, voice curt. "I don't *think* so. We need at least one — maybe *two* — of those gens online or we're never getting the gate. I'm headed that way as soon as I'm done here. *You should be too.*"

"No, Meg. You *don't get it.*" Jake took a step closer, lowering his voice. "Leon's over there getting *wrecked* by static every time someone runs past. You need to stay the hell away."

"He knows what he signed up for," Meg muttered, not looking at him. "He'll live. Guy's tough as nails. I think he'll forgive a few shocks and a little panic if it gets the doors open faster."

Jake grit his teeth. "Meg, he's *cuffed* to the *furniture*. He can't leave the blast radius."

That stopped her.

Meg set her tools down, eyes hard. "The shocks hurt," she said, slower now, like testing each word for weight. "But they're not *that* bad."

As if on cue, a scream tore through the hallway — ragged, hoarse, and completely unlike the sharp stabs of fear the survivors had heard from each other before.

Both heads snapped toward the sound. Jake winced. Meg didn't move.

The scream faded. Static flickered faintly in the ceiling lights.

Meg stared at the far wall, her knuckles white where they gripped the side of the generator casing.

"You said he's cuffed to something?" she asked, voice quieter now.

Jake nodded, his tone easing. "Yeah. Furniture in the room is metal. It's catching the static. Every time Herman uses one of those wide-area blasts? It jumps to the closest ground."

Meg looked down, her expression unreadable. "And the closest ground is him."

"Exactly."

She was silent for a beat. Then: "I sent Claudette that way a while ago.."

Jake's stomach dropped.

"She's probably already started on one of the gens in the cluster," Meg continued, voice tighter now. "If he gets close again—"

"Leon's gonna take the hit."

Meg's jaw clenched.

"Alright," she said, turning back to the generator with a new focus. "I'll keep Claudette off that side. No sense having her wander into the blast zone blind."

She shot Jake a sharp look. "Whatever the hell you're doing? Do it fast."

Jake resumed his search with renewed urgency, ducking into room after room along the looping hallways. Most of the spaces were empty beyond any kind of function — overturned chairs, snapped monitors, half-empty toolboxes filled with bent screwdrivers and loose screws. Nothing useful. He was making faster time than expected, but the lack of options gnawed at him. Either the keys were stashed somewhere absurd, or they were being moved. Neither possibility sat well.

He passed a hallway junction, angling toward the rotunda. A curved staircase led him up to the observation deck, open windowpanes staring down into the morbid circle of chairs below. Inside, the air felt stale, dead with disuse. The counters were littered with cracked keyboards, old monitors flickering with distorted light, and piles of paperwork that had long since succumbed to mold and rust.

He yanked open one drawer and was met with a heap of rusted scissors and half-melted gauze pads. Another offered nothing but paperwork warped from water damage. A third, hidden behind a binder the size of his head, held an anatomy chart rolled tight — half its labels missing or burned away.

“Jesus, what is this place even *for*?” he muttered, slamming the drawer shut. “What *is* all this shit? Does the Fog just litter junk around for *aesthetic*?”

He reached for the next set, only for a spark to pop at his wrist — a thin arc of static snapping between the drawer handle and the nearest keyboard, shorting out with a loud pop and the smell of singed plastic. Jake hissed and jerked back. The air was humming again.

Jake’s chest tightened.

The next scream came seconds later.

Short. Sharp. Choked off halfway like it had been startled out of someone mid-breath. Jake froze, eyes scanning the walls, listening. He couldn’t tell how far away it was — but that *tone*... That one hadn’t been random. That was *targeted*.

Jake’s breath caught. His head whipped toward the windows, hoping for a glimpse of movement — but the angle was garbage. The rotunda’s observation deck didn’t give a clean sightline into the corridors, and the overhead lights only deepened the shadows.

Frustrated, he spun back toward the desk, eyes catching on the half-lit monitors still glitching faintly in the corner. The system was a mess — screens frozen mid-frame, others jittering like broken film reels — but they were still *active*.

Jake stabbed at the keyboard, flipping through camera feeds. Blank hallway. Broken med bay. Rusted bathroom. Most were distorted messes — glitched overlays and flickering grayscale. But one held, the feed jittering every few seconds like a scratched DVD.

Leon.

He was still in the same position Jake had left him in — kneeling against the cabinet, arm stretched upward at a brutal angle. But now his body had slumped. The cuff kept him tethered upright, but his spine had curled in on itself, his free hand clenched in a death grip against the front of his vest. Whether he was shaking from pain or it was just the jitter of the monitor, Jake couldn't tell. But the stillness in him was wrong. The kind of still you only got when moving made things worse.

Jake leaned in closer, one hand bracing the side of the monitor.

Another feed flickered to life beside it. A hallway view. Empty — except for one figure dead center, face tilted up toward the lens.

Herman.

He stood perfectly still, framed in grainy grayscale, the fringe of his coat swaying slightly as though moved by an unseen wind. His mouth curled upward, and even through the distortion, the expression was unmistakable.

He *knew*.

He was watching the camera. Watching *Jake*.

Jake's stomach turned to ice.

The Doctor raised one hand, flexing as he built up a charge along the arm, then placed his palm flat against the wall beside him.

The screen scrambled briefly from the static burst, but Jake didn't need the audio feed. The scream that followed echoed *through the halls*.

Jake gripped the counter so hard his knuckles went white.

He knew. *He knew what he was doing.*

Leon wasn't just collateral damage anymore — he was *bait*. And Herman was hitting him just hard enough to make sure someone *e/se* came running.

Three more rooms. Three more dead ends.

Jake found himself in what looked like a side office near the rear of the wing — smaller than the others, but strangely pristine. The floors were clean. The desk was polished. The air didn't reek of mildew or rust. Unlike the chaos outside, this space felt... deliberate.

Jake stepped in cautiously, eyes scanning the room. Bookshelves lined the walls, packed tight with dusty hardcovers and rows of glass containers he didn't dare inspect too closely. The desk in the middle of the tight space was heavy wood — lacquered and carved, unlike the folding metal garbage in the rest of the facility.

It was the only room in the building that felt like someone *claimed* it.

He flipped through a few loose papers on the desk — scrawled notes in a sharp, arrogant script. Diagrams of neurological pain centers. Shock vectors. Stress patterns.

Jake snorted. “Of *course* you keep a journal.”

He rifled through the rest of the notes quickly — nothing useful — then moved to the drawers. The top one held broken fountain pens and a torn patient file. The second, an unused set of syringes in pristine packaging.

Next drawer — a pristine pair of metal restraints, polished to a fine gleam, resting on a folded cloth like a trophy.

Jake grimaced and slammed it shut. “What the *fuck* is wrong with this guy...”

He exhaled sharply, shaking off the chill crawling up his spine.

He reached for the final drawer, fingers slipping off the smooth lacquered handle. Frowning, he adjusted his grip and tugged harder.

No movement.

Jake tried again. Still nothing.

Locked solid.

“One locked drawer in a building full of garbage...” He muttered, already pulling back. “Yeah. If I were an egotistical freak with a god complex, this is *exactly* where I’d keep the fucking keys.”

He reached automatically for his toolbelt, cursing to himself as his hands hit empty air where a screwdriver should have sat.

His last one was still somewhere under a gurney in Leon’s room, long gone.

All he had left was a blunt file, a wrench too big for the gap, and a mostly spent medkit. No leverage. No finesse tools.

He raked a hand through his hair, scanning the room for anything else — a pry bar, a lamp base, a chunk of wall maybe — anything he could use to break in. The drawer was solid wood, sure, but maybe with the right angle—

He stepped back, testing the floor space.

Too tight.

He wouldn’t get enough leverage to kick it clean. Not without bouncing off the desk or losing his balance.

Maybe the handle then? If he could crack the handle off and pull the latch from the inside, that might work.

The walls hummed.

A static pulse rolled through the floor, deep enough to buzz behind his teeth — followed by a low ripple of laughter that was too distant to echo right.

Jake’s expression darkened.

He stepped into the hallway, one hand already tightening around the file at his hip.

“Hang on, Leon,” he murmured. “I’m getting there.”

And with one last glance at the locked drawer, Jake turned and sprinted for the hallway, leaving the pristine office behind, and the locked drawer waiting.

Chapter 4: Current Surge

Meg had found Claudette just outside the main wing, crouched low beside a collapsed supply chest, hand resting on the handle of her medkit like she was ready to spring into action. She looked up at the sound of footsteps, startled until she registered who it was. She clocked the tension in Meg — the way she shifted her gaze around like she would rather be anywhere else in the moment.

“We gotta go. Leave the gens.” She kept her voice low; no doubt she had also heard the Doctor stomping around in the distance.

“Why? I was halfway done one of them! I was just headed back to—”

“Jake wants us clear of the area. Apparently, Leon is stuck in one of the rooms and is taking damage every time a chase passes by.”

“He’s down here somewhere?” Claudette asked, glancing down the hall as she stood. “Why aren’t we helping him?”

Meg shifted uncomfortably. “Jake said stay a full building away. Said he’s working on it. I didn’t get a lot of details, just that it’s... it’s not good.”

Claudette rubbed her arm, unease setting in. “I... thought I heard someone yell earlier. But I couldn’t tell if it was one of ours or just... you know. Fog noise.”

She’d been partway through one of the three gens clustered around the central hallway when the Doctor had shorted the entire section out earlier. The static had crawled up her spine like a living thing, slamming into the walls and rattling the equipment around her. Somewhere in the middle of it, she’d heard something — faint, but sharp. A voice. A yell. Distorted by the charge.

She’d heard that kind of sound once before — from David, years back, when a trial had gone bad and his hip dislocated mid-sprint. That scream had branded itself into her memory, and now it came crawling back from wherever she’d buried it. It had to have been one of the boys, caught up in the same blast she barely managed to get outside of. And if it wasn’t Jake...

Had Leon been in there this whole time?

Claudette hesitated. Meg was already trying to nudge her away from the area, but just leaving felt wrong somehow.

“If Leon *is* stuck... and no one else is around... shouldn’t we at least check?”

Meg didn’t answer at first, seemingly just as reluctant as Claudette was to abandon a teammate. Leon wasn’t the type to suffer quietly. He yelled when things went bad. He barked for help. He cursed at the Entity. And yet... no one had heard a word from him except screams.

And even those hadn’t sounded right.

“...Let’s check the doors,” she said finally. “Just until we figure out which room he’s in.”

Claudette nodded, already moving.

She didn’t run. But her pace had a purpose now — something tight coiled between her shoulders. Meg hesitated a second before following, footsteps soft behind her. They didn’t speak again. The air felt heavier with each step.

The eighth shock didn't knock Leon over — though that wasn't much of a victory. Even if he had wanted to, the cuffs didn't let him fall far enough.

He sagged against the filing cabinet, knees collapsed beneath him. His face was half-buried against the cabinet, forehead pressed to the cool metal, chest rising in stutters, as his breath wheezed shallow and uneven.

He'd stopped trying to stand back up somewhere around pulse five. The shocks weren't random anymore. He'd figured that out two, maybe three hits ago. It was hard to keep track now.

At first, he'd thought it was just timing — bad luck, wrong place, unlucky blast. But then he'd started hearing the pattern. The shuffling footsteps. The click of dress shoes outside the door. The pause.

Then the pain.

It didn't take much to figure out what was happening.

He was bait.

And judging by the voices in the hallway, it was working.

He could hear the girls talking in the hallway outside — Meg's boots squeaking faintly on the tile, Claudette's voice rising and falling in concerned confusion.

The worst part was how it *almost* made him feel safer.

Leon clenched his jaw, shifting slightly as his cuffed shoulder screamed in protest. They were entirely too close. He could still hear Herman lurking somewhere not far off. The occasional hiss of static in the walls. The echo of a coat brushing tile.

He swallowed hard and pressed his forehead harder to the cabinet, trying to breathe quiet.

If Herman caught them too...

Meg and Claudette crept along the edge of the cluster, checking each door with cautious efficiency. The Doctor's presence stalked nearby, his heavy steps rising and falling like a tide—close enough to hear, but never consistent enough to track. The terror radius kept flaring, static thickening in the air before fading again like a faulty heartbeat.

So far, he hadn't noticed them.

Didn't mean he wasn't *waiting*.

Claudette gestured for Meg to hang back as they approached the corner of a side hall. Her hand hovered near the remains of what was once a rusted security gate when the air changed. Her skin prickled. The hair on her arms rose.

Meg passed by, her hand within inches of connecting with the bars.

"Don't—!"

Claudette yanked her back just in time.

"What the hell—?!"

A violent *crack* split the silence as static surged through the bars, leaping in arcs that sizzled and snapped like teeth. The charge danced across the frame, lashing outward with enough force to bite at Meg's hand as she stumbled away. Her hand went instantly numb and she barely stifled a yelp, clutching her wrist.

They ducked into a nearby doorway, hearts hammering as they waited for the sparking to fade. The current chased itself across nearby metal — leaping across wall rails and abandoned carts until the last crackle vanished around a corner.

For a breath, everything was still.

Then came the sound.

A *thud*, dull and heavy, as something — or someone — collided repeatedly with something solid nearby. A grunt followed; muffled, but sharp enough to register pain.

Meg and Claudette exchanged a wide-eyed glance.

Without a word, they followed the sound.

They rounded the corner just in time to see Leon's body slam against the metal cabinet, bright sparks of electricity arcing between the nearest furniture and whatever skin they could find.

His head hit first — bouncing off the surface with a sickening *clunk* — followed by a violent jolt down his spine as one leg kicked out involuntarily, the rest of him seizing against the cabinet's drag. Every inch of him shuddered, teeth clenched, breath locking in his throat as his back arched off the cabinet. His cuffed shoulder twisted with the motion, muscles locking hard enough to pull his torso sideways before the shock finally relented.

Claudette bolted.

She dropped to her knees beside him, hands hovering in the air — uncertain where to touch without worsening the damage. Leon had slumped back again, breath ragged, muscles still twitching along one side like his body couldn't tell if the threat had passed. His eyes were still open, but looked glazed and unfocused, as if he had completely checked out of the moment.

"Hey—" Claudette's voice broke slightly as she reached for his temple. "Leon?"

She gently moved his head, brushing sweat-slick hair back to check for injury. The moment her fingers grazed his skin, his head jerked, neck going taut beneath her hands. His eyes fluttered, shaking lightly for a moment, then finally *focused* — or at least tried to. His gaze wandered and slid around him, until finally finding Claudette with a thin film of confusion tinted with relief.

"...wh—" More of a confused breath than a question, as his misfiring system tried to piece together why he was on the floor.

A bloom of pain pushed aside the haze, and he heaved a hissed stream of air through his teeth, spine curling slightly as his shoulder throbbed in protest from being yanked so low during the shock.

Right. The cuff. But when did the girls get here?

“God, Leon...” Claudette’s voice wavered, incredulous and breathless. “Why didn’t you say anything?”

Leon blinked slowly, voice hoarse, raw around the edges.

“Tried,” he rasped. “D— didn’t get far.”

To one side, Meg tracked the arcs of residual static along the far wall — hissing angrily against metal debris before fizzling out.

Jake hadn’t been kidding. If anything, he’d *undersold* it.

A knot of guilt twisted in her gut as she thought of how close she’d come to sending Claudette straight into that field alone. That could’ve ended a lot worse.

But the guilt burned off quickly, replaced by pure, pointed fury.

“Oh, *fuck this*. This is absolute *bullshit*.” Her voice was sharp as flint. “I don’t *think* so.”

She grabbed the chain attached to Leon’s cuff and *yanked*, wrapping an old rag around her hands like an impromptu insulator just in case the cabinet still had any static charge left. The metal groaned, scraping loudly as she leaned back with her full weight — but the base didn’t budge.

Leon grimaced, pulling in a slow breath as the room tilted slightly.

“You *can’t*... stay here,” he warned, voice strained, slurred around the edges, but firmer now. “He’s trying t’ draw you out.”

Meg didn’t let go. “We’re not leaving you here to get shocked into a stroke. This thing’s gotta give eventually.”

Claudette was still at his side, gently adjusting the way his arm hung from the cuff.

“Can you move your fingers?” she asked urgently. “I need to check if—”

Leon’s breathing hitched. His head slumped back against the cabinet with a dull *clunk*, eyelids fluttering as he tried to blink back the gray that teased the edges of his vision.

He forced the words out through a tight jaw. “Get... out. B’fore he comes back.”

Claudette glanced up at Meg, then back to Leon, frustrated. “We *can’t* just— damn it, you’re destabilizing. He’s *burning* your nerves. You’re already spasming.”

Leon shoved lightly at Meg’s leg with his free hand, trying to push her back. He shook off some more of the creeping sparks around his vision and forced his voice to steady. He *had* to get them out of the area, and they weren’t going to leave if they thought he was collapsing into himself.

“Look. Jake’s hunting the keys. He’ll get me loose. But you two need to *go*.”

He exhaled hard, trying to will his body still. “Last thing we need is a *daisy chain* of survivors getting fried one by one.”

He looked at them both, gaze sharp despite the haze settling over him.

“Get back to the campfire. I’ll make it there... *eventually*.”

Claudette sat back on her heels, flexing her fingers into her lap like she couldn’t decide whether to reach for Leon again or just *do something*. Anything. But there wasn’t much left to do.

He was already in rough shape — when they had come in, he barely looked like he recognized where he was — and Herman wasn’t easing off. If anything, his cruelty was escalating. Dragging this out. Making a point.

Moving on was really the only logical choice.

Plus, matter how bad it got, eventually the Fog WOULD bring him back to the campfire.

...Whatever was left of him, anyways.

Claudette’s gaze lingered on the doorway. Her gut screamed that walking away was wrong — but logic didn’t leave room for better options.

“I don’t want to just...” she started, then swallowed hard, looking up at Meg. “But if we don’t go, he’s going to make it worse.”

Meg kicked away from the cabinet with a frustrated cry. She’d known from the moment they’d walked in that Leon had already accepted this outcome. He was never expecting

them to get him out. Just to *go*. To leave. To not get added to the roster of broken bodies littering the map. It burned.

But that chain was stronger than she was, and the longer they stayed there, the greater the chance of the Doctor finding them and adding them to the collection. She swore, dragging a palm down her face before stepping over to help Claudette back to her feet.

“You better be right about Jake,” she muttered tightly.

Leon’s head lolled slightly to the side, and he gave a lopsided, tired half-smile.

“I usually am.”

The lights above them flickered — a soft static pulse that passed overhead like the distant tail of a storm. Both women turned and slipped through the doorway, their footsteps retreating fast into the hall.

For a few seconds, the room held still.

Then Leon exhaled — slow and shaky — as if holding his breath had been the only thing keeping him upright this long.

He slumped back against the cabinet, legs unfolding out of their cramped brace. The shift made the cuff pull tight again, dragging his arm upward until the nerves sparked. He closed his eyes, willing back the nausea from how badly the room kept tilting as he tried to breathe through it.

It wasn’t much — his ribs ached too much to fill fully, and his lungs felt crackled at the edges — but at least he didn’t have to hold it steady for someone else’s sake.

The stillness wasn’t peace. It was just the absence of people he had to *lie* to.

His free hand twitched on the floor beside him, fingers curling slightly before losing strength and going still. One shoulder hitched in a delayed shiver — his body still trying to process the last blast as if it hadn’t registered yet that it was over.

He knew what muscle fatigue looked like. He’d studied shock trauma, nerve damage, all of it. He knew exactly what signs were setting in now.

He just didn’t know how many more he could take.

He tilted his head back against the cabinet, eyes drifting up to the chain above.

“...Better be close, Jake,”

Jake *was* close.

He was loaded down with junk—twisted bedframe scraps, broken IV stands, a section of handrail yanked off the wall with sheer panic-strength. Anything that looked solid enough to break open wood was fair game now. Subtlety had left the building six shocks ago. It clattered noisily as he staggered back through the empty doorframe of the Doctor’s office, dumping the pile at his feet like a desperate scavenger at a workbench.

The hallway lights above him flickered.

A scream echoed faintly from somewhere behind the walls.

It didn’t sound like the first ones.

This one was shorter. Rougher.

Jake’s face tightened, jaw clenching so hard it hurt.

“Son of a bitch,” he muttered, grabbing a chunk of rail that looked fairly sharp on one end. “Just hang in there...”

He dropped to his knees beside the locked desk drawer again, wedging the metal between the seam. It was a crude angle, not ideal for leverage, but he didn’t care. He rammed it in with a sharp jerk, enough to make the wood groan, then chipped at the edges with the jagged end, carving out a wider gap.

“You better have something *useful* in you,” he breathed, voice low and harsh.

He slammed the rail back into the drawer seam and heaved sideways, the wood groaning against the pressure.

“Come on, come on...”

Another shock lit up the air. He felt it before he heard it — *the air shifted*, like it had been pulled taut and then slapped. The static crackled through the walls. It hit something metal hard enough that Jake could hear the *furniture* rattle.

Leon's scream followed a heartbeat later.

Brief.

Only half-formed.

It cut out partway, leaving a silence so sharp it felt surgical.

Jake swore under his breath, twisting the rail like a crowbar. The wood groaned, splintered, and snapped — a sliver of lacquered veneer shooting up and nearly clipped his cheek.

The drawer shifted.

He froze.

Then yanked.

Chapter 5: Tarnished Steel

The drawer gave way with a cracking snap —
Too loud. Far too loud for a building where silence was the only safe currency left.

Jake flinched, jaw clenching as the sound echoed out through the sterile quiet. He stilled, one hand still frozen against the wood, ears straining for the rhythm of boots on tile or the flicker of static bleed in the air.

Nothing. Yet.

He exhaled carefully through his nose, fingers tightening on the warped handle. Planting a foot against the base of the desk, he pulled again, bracing his weight into it. The splintered wood protested with a dull groan as it scraped against the twisted bracket still trying, uselessly, to hold the drawer shut.

The makeshift crowbar — a bent chunk of railing he'd scavenged from the stairwell — slipped from his grip and hit the floor with a metallic clatter.
Jake didn't wait for the echo to fade.

He shoved his hands into the gap and *ripped*, the drawer tearing free with a final shudder, fragments of lacquered wood shearing off under his fingers.

He dug in fast — no time for care, no thought spared for preservation. Just fingers tearing through decades of damp files and soot-stained paper, old notes soaked through and curling at the edges. Pages dissolved under his touch, mold blooming like bruises across forgotten ink. The drawer vomited its contents to the floor — a mess of shredded vellum, crumbling edges, the occasional splash of something he didn't want to name.

A few metal implements rolled free: surgical scissors dulled to uselessness, an old spoon warped into a lazy curl, a leather strap whose cracked buckles were flecked with something dry and reddish that he told himself — firmly — was rust.

He shoved it all aside.

And there — barely visible, half-tucked beneath a square of stiff cloth — a glint.

Jake fished it out carefully.

A key.

His breath caught. Then another glint. A second.

They were handcuff keys. A pair of them. So much smaller than he thought they would be, thin, clearly designed to fit only one kind of lock.

And rusted.

Deep-set corrosion traced along the edge of the first one like veins. The second looked slightly better, but it, too, was tarnished — a dull, almost green-tinged patina marring the pin. They looked entirely too fragile to be of use; the corruption of the Entity having clearly sunk deep into the metal just like everything else that might have once been useful.

Jake stared at them, a cold pit forming in his gut.

“...Fuck.”

He rubbed one hard against his shirt, trying to clear the buildup, but the oxidation flaked like scabs, and underneath was just more of the same. He thought briefly about trying to chip the buildup off against something, then rejected it. The moment the thought had arrived, so did the vision of the key snapping *in* the cuff, leaving Leon trapped with a broken stem and no second chance.

No.

They might work. Maybe.

If he was careful.

And lucky.

He didn't have time to doubt.

Jake turned, keys in hand — and stopped. The lights overhead *twitched*, the fluorescents stuttering like a skipped heartbeat. The air *flexed*, pressure building in the doorframe behind him, and with a soft whine like a rising scream, the hallway bathed in red.

No time.

He bolted.

The nearest window frame was half-splintered already, and he threw himself through it in one motion — boots clipping the wood, arm up to guard his head — and tumbled into the hall beyond in a skidding roll.

The hallway was already hissing when he hit the corner — the air charged, laced with static that prickled down his spine like pins. Behind him, the air screamed with a high frequency whine, coupled with the heavy boot-falls of something significantly larger than him, moving at great pace.

Herman had *definitely* heard the drawer break.

Jake didn't look back. He couldn't afford to. A burst of static ripped through the corridor behind him, snapping off a nearby panel and detonating against the floor just out of reach. Sparks skittered across the tiles, hot enough that he felt the heat on his shins. His feet skidded. Momentum stole his balance for a second — then he caught himself, twisting hard as he slammed shoulder-first into the next corner and careened down a new hallway.

One of the keys flicked out of his grip mid-turn, bounced once, and slid across the linoleum with a traitorous rattle.

"Shit—!"

He spun out wide, snatched it back up in a near dive, and didn't pause to check for damage. The seconds were *bleeding*.

He needed to lose him. Somehow.

Loop a vault. Take a back route. Anything.

But Léry's didn't offer clean chase paths. Just rows of crumbling treatment rooms, cluttered therapy spaces, wheelchairs left to rot in the corners. Blind spots and perfectly

arranged grid-like hallways. He was good at dodging, sure, but even he couldn't run forever. With the girls keeping a low profile and working on the side generators, there was nobody to peel Herman off on so he could catch a break.

So, a hiding spot, then.

Lockers were a joke. Too loud. He was moving too fast. The slam would carry down the hallway and paint a red arrow over his position. He would have to duck behind something and pray that the movement wasn't seen before the Doctor could round a corner. He had seen Nea do it entirely too often, just dipping around something and vanishing into a bush like she had never been there. She made it look so easy — as if the Fog itself wanted her to disappear.

How hard could it be?

Another burst of static shot overhead — a whipcrack of voltage that sent ceiling tiles rattling in their frames. The air sparked, raw and sharp, and Jake barely had time to twist away as flecks of light burst down onto his shoulders like electric hail. He hissed between his teeth, dropped low, and dove through the nearest doorway just as the next pulse detonated behind him.

The world exploded in white light.

Tile cracked. Something metal shrieked against the wall.

Jake didn't look. He was already crawling.

The room was tight — much smaller than he had hoped — and he slid around the edge of what looked like a drained hydrotherapy basin, ceramic walls chipped, grime-stained. It loomed just barely high enough to offer cover if he stayed low.

He dropped flat beside it and pressed himself into the crook where tile met basin, chest flush to the floor, body molded tight to every possible inch of safety.

And waited.

His breath caught.

Footsteps. Slow. Measured.

Heavy enough to shake dust from the ceiling.

The terror radius set his heart screaming against his ribs, Herman's presence looming like a wall in the doorway. The sparks that danced across his gear made loud pops as they arced between muscle and the doorframe. One arc leapt sideways and lit up a rusted bar in the hallway. Jake flinched, but only internally. His jaw was locked tight. Eyes wide. Pulse screaming.

Heavy breathing, tense with irritation, wafted through the room. Jake could hear every movement.

The rasp of fabric, the low exhale through grit teeth, the subtle tick of a voltage regulator resetting.

If the Doctor turned just a few degrees—

If he spotted a boot edge, or the faint smear of dust where Jake had landed...

Jake stared at the crack between basin and wall like it held the *only safe geometry left in the universe*.

He didn't blink.

A *slam* shattered the stillness — a locker, not even 10 feet away. Metal on metal, loud enough to ring.

Jake jerked, breath catching in his throat.

The footsteps paused.

Then turned.

An annoyed snarl.

Heavy footfalls out the far door.

Silence.

His heart rate slowly calmed as the radius passed down the hall.

He finally allowed himself a full breath.

Jake waited.

Three seconds.

Five.

Counted them out in the gaps between heartbeats.

And only then —

only then — did he move.

His body wasn't moving right anymore.

Twitches sparked randomly through his legs, his back, his side — all of it out of sync with anything he actually told them to do. He could feel everything, still, but it came in broken pieces. Signals half-delivered. Feedback loops without return.

His heart had given up on rhythm long ago. It beat now in panicked stutters, sometimes too fast, sometimes too slow, lurching through his chest like a drunk trying to remember the steps to a song no one else could hear.

His vision shimmered at the edges.

A shape loomed in the doorway, blinking in and out of his vision. Massive. Looming. A silhouette writhing with violet static, jagged edges bleeding into the light.

He would have flinched from it if any part of him was obeying.

The light shifted, and the figure was gone.

One of the Doctor's *echoes*, then. Hallucinated fragments. They came more often now. He knew they weren't real — mostly. But the body didn't care. Especially because there was no way to tell if it was *actually* real until the moment passed.

He counted a breath.

Then another.

Every breath came wrong — too shallow, too sharp. He focused on keeping the inhale relatively even, but it kept skipping. Tripping. The oxygen wasn't landing where it was supposed to. It was making him dizzy, and relatively grateful he was already on the floor.

His fingers flexed around the cuff, trying to keep a grip on the chain to ease the cut of metal into skin. The edges of the cuff were cutting deeper now. He couldn't grip hard enough to make it matter.

His shoulder was *wrong*.

Out.

He could *feel* it grinding with any shift of weight. He couldn't remember when it happened. Just that it had been like this a while now — maybe minutes. Maybe hours. Time was buckling.

There was a sound, distant. Footsteps.

Leon turned toward it.

Or — *tried to*.

The floor didn't move. The angle stayed the same. That wasn't right.

He tried again. Harder.

The world jumped forward slightly, and he realized that he must have blacked out for a moment. Kneeling in front of him, shape fuzzed and backlit — hands on his wrist, voice low and fraying at the edges.

“—got them. Leon? Hey. Hey, come on, stay with me, I got the keys—”

The world didn't *click* into focus so much as smear back toward it. Leon blinked, but the film stayed. His body felt... removed. He knew where it was supposed to be. He just couldn't *get to it* properly.

Something tugged at the cuff above him.

Jake fought with the keyhole, the small piece of metal fumbling in his fingers. The skin beneath the cuff was angry and torn, edges blackened with dried blood and weeping slowly against the metal with every shift. It was being absorbed by what looked like a chunk of an old rag. It seemed that at some point, Leon had tried to insulate the wrist by ramming the rag around it between skin and cuff. The fabric looked charred in spots. It was hard to tell if the effort had helped at all.

He winced as the skin seemed to break open more with his fussing, but the more damaged key was refusing to seat properly. Rusted. Swollen. Bits of reddish metal flaked off as he tried to get it into position, the pin of the key threatening to bend under the effort. Frustrated, he slammed it down on a nearby gurney and lined up the second key.

Down the hall, a generator flared to life with a roar that scattered nearby crows into a frenzy. Small, rapid footsteps hurried in his direction. Jake was still hunched beside him, trying to coax the second key into the lock. His hands were shaking now — not fear, just urgency; too much adrenaline and too little margin for error.

The first key hadn't made it. This one *had* to.

Meg skidded into the doorway, catching herself just short of a full slide across the dust and broken cement.

"We only need one more," she gasped, hopeful. "It's going to *need* to be one of the three."

Jake didn't even look up. "Help me. Get in here and brace him a bit — he's pulling the cuff down too hard. I can't get the lock lined up."

Meg blinked — surprise flashing through the exhaustion.

"You *found* the keys?"

"No time. Get him steady."

She dropped to her knees, all motion, all hands. Leon didn't react at first — just swayed slightly as she caught under his arms, gently lifting his torso up enough to ease the weight off the chain. His eyes fluttered, his head slumping sideways with a relieved sigh as the tension came off the dislocated shoulder.

Jake hissed a quiet “C’mon...” through his teeth, twisting the key again. He felt the pin resist, then shift — metal scraping metal — before the cuff *clicked* open with a tired little pop. He let out a relieved chuckle, pulling the cuff free from the damaged skin.

No longer pinned above him, Leon’s arm fell heavily against Meg. The shoulder was at an angry angle, wrist raw and bleeding sluggishly, fierce red marks snaking up the arm and across his neck like lightning. His head lolled against her shoulder, no resistance left to even try lifting it.

“Jesus...” Meg breathed, quiet now. Alarm tucked deep behind her voice. “How many times did he even get hit?”

Jake was already moving to stabilize him, pushing gear aside to reach Leon’s other side.

“I lost track after eight,” he muttered, still rushing. “There were more. I know there were more.”

“I heard at least two after we left...” she said, shifting to cradle more of the weight. “Good grief, Leon. How the *fuck* are you even alive?”

His chest hitched a couple of times in what could have been a chuckle, one hand trying to grip at her pant leg to pull himself upright to no success.

“’m mag’c.”

His head drooped, eyes fluttering lightly, and Jake quickly scooped an arm around his injured side to brace the weight as the two of them fought to get him mobile.

“Hey,” Jake said gently, ducking under Leon’s arm to help lift him. “No naps yet, man. We gotta move.”

Jake hauled Leon out through the doorway with Meg’s help, dragging him clear of the sparking echo-chamber as fast as they could manage. The Doctor’s footsteps were gone, but Jake didn’t trust the silence. Not with how well the bastard could double back.

Leon didn’t fight the movement.

Didn’t offer very much help either.

Just groaned once — low and thin — as they got him moving, leaning heavily between them as he fought to keep his legs moving. Roughly 4 hallways from that cursed room,

his vision started smearing again. His head kept dropping forward, as if he was fighting sleep. He made a soft distressed sound, trying to shift weight to get the others to stop.

Just wait for a moment.

Let him rest.

Stop the world from bleeding color in odd directions.

Jake planted a hand on his chest to keep him upright, sharing a look with Meg.

“Hey. Stay with me. Talk to me. Are you ok?”

He tried...

He dragged in a shaking inhale, words delayed, the hallway around him shifting in stuttering lurches.

The hallway tilted around him, the lights above pulsing in double-exposure.

His legs were still moving, but he couldn't feel the floor anymore.

“I... I don't... feel—”

He swallowed hard, forcing the rest out.

“I think I'm— I think—”

Another tremor hit — small, sharp — surging through his neck and chest like a loose wire sparking inside him. His breath stuttered.

“I—wait— I can't—”

His whole face drained out at once, the sentence caught in a broken half-syllable that never finishes, and in that instant, he dropped, head slumping down, chin hitting chest.

Jake and Meg nearly fell under the sudden deadweight as his knees gave out under him, Meg squeaking with surprise as she tried to stand fully upright against the pull.

A nearby waiting room would have to serve for a break, and they manhandled Leon down to the floor, leaning him back against a dusty seat that provided at least a bare minimum of cover from being spotted from the doorways. His head lolled back against the seat, unfocused slivers of blue barely visible through lightly twitching eyelids.

Meg dropped down into a seat across from him, panting and looking nervously back the way they came, while Jake verified that Leon was in fact still breathing. Other than the stuttered rise and fall of his chest, he was completely out.

“Kind of surprised he even made it this far.” Jake sat back against another seat, using his shoulder to keep Leon from sliding off to one side.

“No kidding.” Meg watched him for a moment, trying to not focus too hard on the way random muscles seemed to shiver in him. “...if he’s down... now what?”

“Fuck,” Jake muttered, scrubbing a hand through his hair. “Okay. Okay, think.”

They still had a gen left.

The prime triad. Worst possible spot. No cover. No soft choke points.

Herman would patrol it hard — like he always did — just waiting for someone dumb enough to risk a touch.

If Claudette could solo it, maybe they could run interference. Pull Herman wide and get him chasing. It’s not like he and Meg weren’t fast enough to volley him back and forth.

But then what?

Even *if* the last gen popped...

Even *if* the gates opened...

Even *if* Herman didn’t catch them before they reached it...

How in the hell were they supposed to *carry* him?

Assuming they could get him semi-alert and mobile again, his shoulder was shot. His legs were unreliable at best. There was no way in hell he was going to make it across the yard, through a gate, into the Fog, and out the other side in this state.

And even if they dragged him through...

Jake glanced over.

The bruises.

The *scorch marks*.

This wasn't a trial injury. It was environmental. Would the Fog even heal it? Passing through the Fog via the gates or hatch had a significantly lower impact on the body than anything else, usually only glossing over whatever they had failed to repair en-route. Survivors had been returning to camp for weeks now with random injuries that were barely scabbed over, provided they didn't get them from a killer or a hook.

He looked at Meg.

She looked back.

Neither said a word.

Leon wheezed softly between them — breath like it was playing tug-of-war with gravity.

And they both knew.

This wasn't going to work.

They needed another way out.

Chapter 6: Bargaining Chip

The waiting room was dim, sterile, and still. Just beyond the cracked glass of the entrance, the Fog crept like a living thing, curling and slinking along the floor. The quiet was thick. Unnatural.

Claudette found them not long after finishing the generator she'd been working on. There was only one left to go, but she knew she couldn't head back toward *that* hallway — not after the screams that had followed her out. Instead, she'd traced the outer ring of rooms, hunting for Meg.

She spotted them in a waiting room four hallways over. A quick scan around the area told her Herman hadn't found them yet. No static buzz. No shadowed figure rounding the corner. Nothing.

Ducking quickly inside, her eyes locked on Leon. Relief hit first — he was free. The cuffs were gone. But then the rest of the picture registered, and relief twisted into alarm.

He was slumped back against the chairs, barely upright, his legs sprawled on the floor like someone had just dropped him there and walked away. Jake was braced on one side, body curved in to keep Leon from tipping, his full focus on the angry red marks scorched across Leon's wrist.

Every few seconds, Leon's chest hitched in a shallow, rasping breath. Nothing else moved.

Claudette shed her jacket without a word and bunched it behind Leon's head, trying to cushion the harsh angle where seat met neck. The moment she leaned him back against it, he sighed — small and breathy, but real.

It settled something sharp in her chest.

"Is he going to be ok, do you think?"

Meg looked up from across the room. "He's alive, somehow."

Meg was pacing in a tight loop nearby, boots scuffing against the tiled floor, arms crossed so tight it looked like she might snap her own ribs. Every few seconds, she flicked a glance toward the corridor like she expected the Doctor to appear out of nowhere.

Claudette dropped to her knees beside the boys, careful and methodical despite the obvious panic in her face. She placed two fingers at Leon's neck, then moved his chin gently to check for responsiveness. There was a hitch in his breathing, a rattling catch that made her shoulders tense. His eyes were unfocused, pupils blown entirely too wide. If he recognized her at all, it didn't show.

He didn't seem to be unconscious — more suspended between asleep and catatonic — but at least he didn't seem to be actively crashing in that exact moment. Small favor from the Fog, she supposed. If they could survive multiple cuts, toxins, and being impaled on hooks with nothing more than a band-aid, maybe something in the Fog was keeping him going too.

It was more than she'd expected, honestly.

This kind of thing wasn't her wheelhouse. She could handle bleeding, treat infections, even splint a limb if she had to. But this? This was something else entirely.

Still, she was the closest thing they had to a medic. That had to count for something.

Right?

Her hands trembled as she pulled back, brushing a fleck of ash from his collarbone.

"He's stable. Kind of." Claudette breathed. "But only just. There's... not much I can do without real tools. Or meds. Or time. I don't know if the Fog's going to patch this fully on its own."

Meg shook her head. "We can try to carry him to the gate, at least. Hope the transition does enough to stabilize him."

Claudette hesitated. "The Fog heals trial injuries. We know that. Bleeding, bruises, broken bones... if it happened as part of the trial, it gets fixed. Mostly. But... this?" She gestured softly to Leon. "This wasn't one wound. It's systemic. Burnout. Neurological damage. Maybe cardiac. And it wasn't even clean — this wasn't a hook, or a weapon. This was... torture. Layered and prolonged. The Fog might not recognize it as something to fix. If we bring him back through the gate like this..."

She didn't finish the thought.

Meg rubbed her face and let out a sharp breath. "So, what are you saying? We just *leave him here?*"

"*Obviously* not." Claudette snapped at her, "But I'm not seeing a way to get him back to the campfire without risking a complete collapse that we can't fix. Even if a hatch opened right here so we didn't have to move him, the Fog would bring him back in who knows what condition. It barely manages to clear normal injuries when we leave. And if we get him back and he dies at camp, then what? There's no precedent for that! We have *no idea* what would happen!"

She rocked back on her heels, hands clenched in her lap, fighting the sinking dread curling at her edges.

"I don't know what to do here."

Jake had been quiet while the girls spoke, chewing over every word like they might unstick something in his brain. Each option seemed just as bad as the last. The hatch

and the gate were both off the table—too risky, too uncertain. Either path meant dragging Leon out of the trial and hoping the Fog did something merciful, but the odds were grim. Claudette was right. The Fog was finicky even on a good day. Unreliable. It barely cleaned up *normal* wounds. And this? This was a total system failure.

Although...

His fingers curled tight against his knee, jaw tight as he worked through the other half of the thought — the one he didn't want to say out loud yet.

There *was* a point where it worked overtime on someone, fixing trial injuries so efficiently that it sometimes would repair damage that even the survivor didn't know they had. It was relatively consistent. Reliable. A complete rebuild from scratch. Not kind, clearly, but practical — the Entity can't run a trial if there are no pieces on the board, afterall.

His stomach twisted. The logic was sound. But the cost?

He dragged a hand down his face.

Meg was going to *punch* him. And Claudette might just join her.

He ran the loop again, trying to find another route. A loophole. Anything to avoid the conclusion he kept circling back to. But no matter how many times he ran it, the result was always the same.

This was the only option that might work.

And it sucked.

God, it sucked so bad.

Jake exhaled slowly, pushing himself to his feet. His hands were slick, but he wiped them against his jeans like that would steady him.

It didn't.

"We do have one more option, here."

Jake looked between them, then down at Leon, avoiding the gaze of the girls. If he didn't look right at them, maybe he wouldn't lose his nerve.

"If the Entity takes someone as a sacrifice... the Fog has to *rebuild* them. Completely. It doesn't have a choice. Otherwise, there's nothing left to throw into the next trial."

Meg stared at him, appalled. "A *hook death*? You're seriously talking about sacrificing him?"

Jake ran a hand through his hair, trying to think. "I mean, do you have a better idea? Hook deaths bring a person back to the campfire a lot more whole than escaping out the gate does half the time. It likely won't fix everything, but it's a lot more efficient than anything else we have available right now."

A heavy silence fell between them. Meg stared out the doorway like the wall might offer her a rebuttal, but her jaw stayed locked.

Jake crouched beside Leon, studying his face. His skin was pale and blotchy in strange patches. The bruising from the cuff had spread in streaks along the electricity burns. He hadn't come around, but Jake knew Leon would be on his side here. He was practical, quick to take action once a viable path had shown itself.

Claudette chewed her lip nervously, mentally mapping out the area. It was a terrible idea, but then again, so was every other one they had come up with. Plus, Jake's idea at least had a track record. They had all seen it. The hook deaths were horrible to experience, but you always came back with much less physical injury than if you had just escaped or bled out. It could work. But they would have to haul Leon between the three of them, and the closest hook she could remember was several rooms over with a very angry psychopath on the prowl.

"None of us can carry him. Not that far."

"Oh, don't tell me even YOU'RE considering this, now?" Meg turned on her, clearly at the limit of her tolerance. The trial had already gone to hell. Now they were just... sitting in a crumbling waiting room, debating the logistics of killing one of their own like it was a strategy meeting?

And worse — Claudette's lack of outrage was only bolstering Jake. His anxious fidgeting was evolving into measured pacing, thoughts coalescing into something more than just theory.

"He'd never make it to a hook, not without help. He can't walk. Can barely breathe. None of us can move him fast or quiet enough."

"And even if we could, we have no way of getting him up there," Claudette flashed an apologetic look at Meg. "Besides, as far as we know, survivors can't sacrifice each other. Probably why the Entity keeps the hooks so high up."

"It has to be a killer. The Doctor would have to do it."

Meg choked back a manic laugh — dry and bitter — at the absolute insanity of it all. Her boots scuffed loudly as she turned back to Jake, arms still tight across her chest.

"So, what, we just go up and ask him? Please, mister psycho killer, can you sacrifice our friend to your boss for us real quick? We're too short to reach the hook ourselves! Yeah, that'll go over really well for us. I'm sure he will just help us out of the kindness of his twisted little heart and not, you know, *put the rest of us through the wringer too*."

Jake flinched slightly at her anger. She wasn't totally off, though. He'd already gone through all of that in his head—and worse. And the solution still sat there like a lead weight on his chest. This was going to be a risk. He inhaled, slow and steady, trying to quiet the hammering in his blood. His voice, when it came, was flat and final.

"One of you finish the half-done gen by the central room. The other goes to the exit gate. As soon as it's powered, you leave. Don't wait for me."

Claudette's eyes widened. "Jake. No. You saw what he did to Leon. He's *angry*. You've been his primary target all match. If you go near him—"

"That's exactly why I *have* to," his voice was sharper than intended, trying to sound more confident than he felt. "He's not gonna listen to you. Or Meg. But me? He's been hunting me since I interrupted his game. That's leverage."

Meg looked like she was biting her own tongue, trying to resist the urge to explode again. "You think you can get him to agree to help? To just... grow a conscience all of a sudden?"

"He doesn't need a conscience. He just needs a reason."

She stared at him, open-mouthed for a second, then threw her hands in the air. “Jake, and I say this with all the love in the world, but that is the *stupidest thing* you’ve ever said.”

“What other option do we have?” he snapped back. “Do you want to drag Leon to the gate and *hope* the Fog decides he’s worth saving? Do you want to *guess* what happens to someone who dies outside the trials? You think the campfire’s gonna *magically fix this?*”

He was breathing hard now. The adrenaline was coming back, his tone rising sharp with the pressure behind his ribs

He looked down at his hand — still stained with flecks of key rust, cold against his skin.

“He’s been on me all match. Ignoring you two. Testing me. Luring me out. That’s something I can *use*.”

Claudette stepped in again, trying to keep him grounded. “You don’t even know if Herman *will* agree to anything. He could just kill you. Or both of you.”

“I know.”

“Jake—”

He held up a hand, voice cracking slightly from the strain. “I know. Okay? I *know*. But we don’t have another play. And you *know* it.”

Before they could argue, before Meg could slap some guilt into him or Claudette could plead for a better answer, Jake turned and started walking.

Everything in him wanted to run the other way. But someone had to fix this.

And it had to be him.

Chapter 7: Terms and Conditions

Jake crept from room to room, listening for any sign of Herman's presence.

He didn't *need* to be stealthy — not for what he had planned—but he wasn't in a rush to blow the others' cover before he even knew if this would work. Deep down, though, he knew that wasn't the real reason.

He was stalling. Dragging his feet, hiding in corners, circling the drain. This was *insane*, no matter how he looked at it.

He had caught the faint edges of the Doctor's terror radius a few rooms back, hovering just at the perimeter like a rabbit watching the edge of a snare. Close enough to start acclimating. Far enough to pretend he could still back out.

Jake ran the options again — third time? fourth? — desperately hoping to find a loophole he'd somehow missed. Some clever workaround. Anything other than this. Because yeah, sure, *technically* he'd be fine in the end. Just another pop back to the campfire, same as always. But the Doctor was a sadist. And *this time*, Jake was handing himself over willingly.

He wasn't stupid. He knew exactly what that meant.

Somewhere behind him, there was the faintest creak of movement — quiet footsteps echoing his own, far enough back to stay out of sight. One of the girls was trailing him, ready to slip in to help if the deal was accepted. They'd figured out who was running the gate and who was staying, then. Good. Smart of them to keep out of view until the last possible second. If this went sideways, no reason for all three of them to go down together.

Jake slowed. Listened.

He could still hear Herman pacing in a loose arc — stalking nearby, probably trying to flush them toward the generator hallway. The last three were clustered together, too tempting a target for a killer to ignore.

He could keep circling. Keep dancing just out of reach.

Or he could suck it up and go.

He took one steadying breath, set his jaw, and stepped around the corner — out into the open.

Herman was *done* with this trial.

The only thing keeping him from quitting the whole charade outright was the gnawing pressure of the Entity's eyes still fixed squarely on his spine.

He'd had one of the pests locked down — neutralized far more efficiently than just bleeding out in the hallway — but the girls had vanished like smoke, and the *one* survivor he would have *liked* to disembowel personally was proving to be the single most aggravating little shit he'd dealt with in weeks. Sabotage at every turn. Flitting through his territory like a cockroach with ADHD. Breaking equipment, baiting chases, *mocking* him.

It was enough to make his static flare just thinking about it.

At this point, he didn't even care if the generators got done. Let them power up. Let the gates open. Let them *run*. He just wanted to spear the saboteur through the eye socket with a jagged IV stand and maybe crush a few tiles for good measure.

The Entity's judgment was already burning in the back of his skull — sharp, electric. Her attention stung. Jake's little *stunt* with the hook had tipped him further into Her disfavor, and he could feel the leash tightening.

One kill. That's all he needed.

Just *one* — and She might let him breathe again.

That was the calculus now. One guaranteed sacrifice to take the edge off the migraine of divine punishment clawing through his thoughts. He could manage that.

And on a personal level? The audacity of these survivors was insulting. Hiding instead of playing. No flair. No drama. No fucking *respect* for the hunt anymore. What was the point of all this if they were just going to *cower*?

He doubled back to check on his prize, staring for a moment at the discarded handcuffs, empty and swinging gently from their spot on the cabinet.

Of course the cop was gone. Of *COURSE*.

He ground his teeth and clenched the baton in his fist hard enough that the current snapped along its length. Three guesses which pest had cut the leash.

If he hadn't diverted toward the last generator's detonation, hoping to pick someone off mid-flee, he might've caught them. A rare lapse in judgment. One he wouldn't make again.

They only had one generator left. And now, all of them were in the same wing.

A bottleneck.

He could practically *feel* the survivors trying to creep their way back toward it.

Perfect.

With deliberate steps, he angled himself toward the final sector, threading through the halls like a wolf circling its cornered prey.

This trial wasn't over yet.

And nobody — *nobody* — was getting out if he had anything to say about it.

When Herman entered the central hallway linking the last of the generators, he didn't expect a roadblock. Yet there Jake stood — centered, unmoving, arms stretched wide across the narrow space as if he were enough to stop a monster.

It was such a stupid pose, so *mockingly* symbolic, that for a split second, Herman nearly burst out laughing.

So. The pest was done running. This could be an easy takedown. No thrill, no chase — just a single, cathartic strike to vent his fury and be done with it. But something in his posture, in the look of his eyes, gave Herman pause.

Not defiance.

Resolve.

Not the kind that shouted or bluffed or begged. The quiet kind. The suicidal kind. The kind Herman had seen in soldiers who stopped flinching once the worst outcome became acceptable.

That... piqued his curiosity. He came to a stop, eyeing the young man curiously.

"I want to make a deal."

Well... this was new. Survivors often begged, pleaded, screamed at him to stop. Sometimes they even tried offering the items they brought through the Fog in appeasement. But attempting a bargain? The absurdity of it made Herman cock his head, eyes narrowing with a flicker of amusement.

"Audacious, aren't we? What part of this makes you think you are in any position to be making *demands*?"

Jake fought back a shiver, took a breath to steel himself, prayed the Doctor didn't notice the light tremor in his hands betraying how hard he was working to *stand still*.

"I'm going to help finish the last generator. The girls will leave through the gate unharmed. You'll send Leon back to the campfire. Through the Entity."

A hook sacrifice. Specifically, the one he had originally been denied. The very same fate Jake had denied his teammate earlier, now offered up like a sacred ritual. Full circle. Poetic. It would be satisfying on principle alone — watching the guilt curdle behind his eyes as he undid his own moral stand — but more than that, it was *useful*. A hook kill guaranteed his offering. No complications. No escape attempts. No malfunctions. One solid sacrifice to ease the pressure in his skull.

Still...

He wasn't in a *rush* to agree.

"I see," Herman's tone dripped bitterness. "And what, pray tell, do *you* offer in exchange for such lavish generosity on my part?"

Jake's face hardened. He lowered his arms, trying to straighten his posture, hoping he looked more confident than he felt.

"Once the others safely gone, I'll let you send me back to the campfire however you want."

A shiver of static surged down Herman's spine, excitement flaring sharp and visceral before he could even mask it. He inhaled, slow and deliberate, and the charge built in his chest like a thunderhead. Electricity crackled along his arms, climbing his sleeves in visible arcs as it danced across his fingertips.

Jake flinched. Just barely. But it was there.

The offer had struck its target.

A *willing* sacrifice.

No hunt. No chase. No wasted effort on disarming or downing or dragging. Just four full minutes — *four* — of undisturbed access to a live, consenting subject before the Fog claimed its due.

Oh, he could *work* with that.

Now *THIS*. This was a bargain worth his attention.

"If I agree to your terms, what guarantee do I have that you won't simply slip away the moment the gate opens?"

Jake blinked, genuinely surprised it had gotten this far.

"I mean... you don't," he admitted. "Just like I've got no guarantee you won't just capture the others anyways and still kill me for the hell of it."

His mouth was dry, tongue sticking slightly to the roof of it. But he held his ground, forced himself not to waver.

"I guess we'd both be taking it on faith."

Jake shifted and held out a hand, his eyes fiercely locked into the Doctor's manic stare, daring him. A dare. A challenge. A goddamn death sentence, sealed with eye contact and hope his guts didn't betray him right there on the floor.

Herman stared at the offered hand, weighting the situation. Survivors often couldn't be trusted, but this one held himself with the conviction of a man who knew full well what he was offering and still chose it. Fascinating.

He breached the gap between them with barely a half step, locking Jake's outstretched hand in a crushing grip that sent sparks licking up his arm like a promise of things to come. Jake gasped through clenched teeth, but didn't pull away.

Good.

Herman pulled him in slightly, enough for Jake to smell the sharp ozone on his breath, feel the faint tremor in the air around him from the static charge crawling through his veins.

His voice lowered to a threatening growl as he towered over the smaller man.

"Should you go back on your end of this, I will *personally* take *every single one* of your people who come through my domain. I will send them back to you *broken* and *charred* after slowly extracting every conscious thought they have *ever* had from their hollowed-out husk of a mind with my *bare hands*. Not a *single one* will be spared until I have taken what is *owed* to me. And every single one will return to the Fog with their last living thought being the knowledge that *you* did this to them. Are we clear?"

Jake's defiant glare cracked ever so slightly, a sheen of terror passing over his eyes. He nodded briefly, and Herman felt the heartbeat under his grip quicken. *Excellent*. The fear would keep him honest. Besides, what he had planned was much more fun when the subject was trying to hold it together and failing beautifully.

Deal accepted.

Herman loomed at the far end of the hallway, keeping just enough distance that his terror radius wouldn't bleed into the survivors' ears. Close enough to monitor. Not close enough to break the illusion of *choice*.

He wasn't about to let Jake out of his sight.

The man had proven himself a persistent thorn, and while Herman now had leverage, he wasn't fool enough to underestimate desperation. If Jake decided to bolt, he'd be on him in a second. But for now, he watched.

Jake and Claudette were hunched over the last generator, working in tandem, both trying to pretend that there wasn't a killer watching their every move from the shadowed end of the corridor.

Jake's relief was subtle but clear — he was glad Meg had gone for the gate. She wouldn't have kept to the plan otherwise. Too stubborn. Too loud. Too *righteous*. He'd have sent both girls on ahead if he could have, but this was much faster with two.

Even from his perch, Herman could see Jake's shoulders trembling. Not from exhaustion — but from sheer effort. The restraint it took to stay put under this kind of pressure was commendable, in a way.

A lesser man would've cracked already.

He had sent the cop back first — Jake had led him back to their hiding place before circling back to the generator. He had put up no resistance, not after so much personalized attention, and only really showed any spark of consciousness when the hook went through him, letting out a quiet, pained sound and grabbing at the metal moments before the Entity's claws ran him through and took him for Her meal.

Satisfying to watch, at the least, even if he didn't have enough in him to scream the way they usually do. Herman could feel the Entity's pressure ease up on his mind slightly at the offering as well, leaving him feeling much less strained. His quota wasn't quite there yet, but at least he wasn't at risk of receiving Her full attention for a while now. That was far more valuable to him right now. He needed Her to leave him be for a while.

This one... was personal.

Down the hall, the generator flared to life. Jake gave Claudette a firm, reassuring nod — *go* — and she didn't hesitate. She slipped past him, creeping along the wall as she passed the Doctor, shrinking away from the slow, gleaming grin he offered her in return.

At least *someone* in this trial had a healthy sense of fear.

In the distance, rust screamed and metal groaned — sharp and strained under years of neglect — marking the gate's slow, shuddering rise. The Fog shifted, its pressure subtly relaxing as the girls crossed the threshold. Gone.

He sighed in mild annoyance, never liking to simply allow an escape. He had contemplated chasing them out, at least making them earn it before pulling back to watch them scramble across the threshold, but the collapse was a limited window and he didn't want to waste a second of it having to navigate back from the gate.

Jake had already moved to the rotunda by the time Herman rejoined him, standing among the Entity's vein-like cracks that spread across the floor as the timer ticked down in their minds. The lights overhead cast a halo around him — arms curled tight around his chest, feet locked in place. It was nearly picture perfect, the way he stood there defiantly resisting the natural instinct to flee.

Herman paused to admire the sight. The survivor hadn't run. Hadn't faltered. No tricks. No tantrum. He had actually *meant it*.

Herman respected that.

It would make this all the more rewarding.

A wide grin peeled across his face as he stepped into the light, current dancing eagerly along his shoulders, snapping from nearby chairs like leashed lightning. His voltage was already rising — amped higher than it had been in months.

Four minutes. More than enough.

He raised a hand towards Jake, sparks licking across fingers with sharp, deliberate arches.

“When you see Mr. Richter, do be sure to pass along my regards.”

The lights flared — flooding the rotunda in an unnatural white — and somewhere, buried in the static and the sirens, a scream echoed through the walls.

Chapter 8: Collateral Damage

Jake slammed back into existence with a soundless scream, his lungs seizing around phantom fire. The air tore into him like barbed wire, too sharp, too dry, too fast — his mind stuttered around his senses in chaotic bursts of disorientation — uncoordinated limbs thrashing violently against the world around him. He clawed at his chest, the ground, whatever limbs or hands were near enough to catch. Anything to anchor himself. Anything to get *out*.

Everything burned. His nerves lit up in jagged afterimages of torment, phantom electricity screaming down his spine and out through his limbs. No position gave relief. No movement lessened it. His mind stuttered and skidded across broken sensory input — sound and color and pressure flooding in all at once, none of it lining up, none of it *making sense*. A hundred fragments of reality all jammed into the same second.

And something was *touching him*.

Hands. Arms. Seemingly *everywhere*. Trying to hold him down. Voices, shouting, distant and warped like they were underwater. Jake *erupted*, flailing against the phantom restraints with every wild, adrenaline-drenched ounce of strength he had left. He couldn't tell if he was hitting the floor or someone's leg or a wall, but one of his fists caught something solid and some of the hands fell away, only to be replaced by even stronger ones. They hooked around his arms and shoulders, *pulled* him upright — someone braced behind him, locking him in place like a seatbelt. He had no balance, no leverage. His feet scrabbled uselessly across the ground.

Everything was too *much*. Too loud, too bright. Light carved white-hot streaks across his vision. Sound hit in smeared vibrations, voices collapsing into meaningless noise. A scream caught in his throat as electricity still danced in phantom arcs along his spine. The arms locked across his chest didn't budge — a steady pressure pinning him in place, anchoring him as he fought and flailed and finally... *broke*. Behind him, someone breathed slow and calm, exhaling soft rhythm into the crook of his neck, like trying to pace him down from the edge.

A voice — low, familiar, more *tone* than any words he could recognize — murmured quiet nonsense against his ear. It didn't matter what they were saying. The *sound* of it sliced through the screaming in his skull, dragging his mind back one fragile thread at a time. The fire in his chest slowed. The shaking dulled.

Jake's limbs sagged, twitching instead of thrashing, the force of his panic bleeding out in great gasping sobs that wracked his whole frame. His breath hitched again and again, caught between pain and grief and exhausted terror.

The grip around him shifted, and he let it — let them pull him sideways, let his face be tucked against warm fabric and steady muscle, away from the worst of the light. The hands that had tried holding him down had softened into grounding touches and exploratory prods against pulse points and mostly healed burns.

His mind swam. Ears roared. The adrenaline was gone but nothing coherent took its place — just static, floating somewhere below the surface of himself.

He felt the world tip, just slightly, somewhere behind his ribs. His consciousness pitched downward, a wave folding in on itself — and Jake let it.

Let it take him. Let the pain go.

Let everything go.

Soft murmurs stirred him back toward the surface — warm voices through the static, low and familiar. How long had he been out?

Jake inhaled, wincing as the scent of burning wood and sweat flooded his senses. Campfire. Damp earth. Cloth soaked with adrenaline and blood. He blinked through the fog, squeezing his eyes shut against the light, body aching down to the bone.

The camp. The other survivors.

Safety.

Pain still throbbed across his ribs, his arms, his spine — but it was distant now, dull. Already the Fog was doing its work, nibbling away at the worst of it. In a few trials, the memory of the pain would fade.

Jake tried opening his eyes again and, through blurred static, caught on a blur of motion a short distance from the fire. Ace sat a little ways off, being gently interrogated by Dwight's medkit. The man looked *rough* — one hell of a black eye blooming across his temple, sunglasses gone, and a shallow cut tracing just beneath his brow. He kept flinching as Dwight dabbed at him, muttering colorful commentary through the fussing.

When he noticed Jake watching, Ace gave a crooked grin and a two-fingered salute — then winced again as Dwight swatted his hand away. Jake exhaled a weak breath that might've been a laugh if he had the energy. Right. That must've been who he hit.

Something shifted against his back, and Jake glanced down to find a familiar scarred forearm wrapped around him, anchoring him to a battered shirt.

David.

He shifted slightly, only to realize he'd been curled against the man. Too tired to be embarrassed. Almost.

Blinking away the haze, he spotted Claudette and Meg chatting quietly with Felix and Leon near the fire. Leon looked tired, his wrist tightly wrapped in layers of gauze. He was a little slouched in on himself, but alert, apparently in discussion over something. Meg caught his gaze and gave a tight smile. Jake let out a long breath and sagged against David's side.

They were OK.

They made it out.

"You back with us?"

David's voice was low and dry with a hint of amusement as he poked gently at Jake's temple.

Jake let out a weak chuckle, breath still shaky. "Think so?"

He pushed himself upright, peeling away from the solid warmth of David's chest with the sluggish reluctance of someone who *very much* would've preferred to stay there. He rubbed at his arms, trying to work life back into the aching muscles.

"Little well done for my tastes," he muttered, flexing his fingers experimentally, "but it feels like everything's still attached."

He glanced across the firelight to where Leon sat, looking very much like he too could use a nap. "You good?"

Leon nodded, voice a little hoarse. "Yeah. Don't remember much after the girls came in, but I'm no worse for wear."

Good. That was good. If Leon was coherent, then it had been worth it.

Jake exhaled and dropped his head again, letting the dizziness ebb out with the fire's warmth. "Fuck," he muttered, "that was *way* worse than his usual mori. My head's still ringing."

David's hand settled on his shoulder, keeping him from tipping over as the world kept pitching gently around his head. "Yeah, that tracks. Doctor gets creative sometimes. Bastard's never satisfied just running the script."

Across the fire, Felix let out a soft snort — dry and humorless.

“That’s an understatement,” he muttered, something unreadable flickering behind his eyes. “Just take your time. The aftershocks’ll pass, but you’re probably gonna have trouble holding anything for a bit.”

Jake flexed his fingers again, watching as they twitched and jumped slightly in response. He may have to stay off gens for a little while, at least until he could hold the wires without his arms trying to choreograph random interpretive dance in the delicate machinery.

He sat in silence for a while, letting the trembling slowly bleed out of his limbs while David traced slow, grounding circles over his back.

Creative, he thought bitterly, really *was* a fucking understatement. He’d taken his fair share of electric shocks before — burned synapses, short-circuited thoughts, the usual Fog-induced brain scrambles. Painful, sure, but fast. Rote. Survivable.

This had been something else entirely.

He could still *hear* the crack of bones locking under their own tension. Still *feel* the collapsing pressure in his chest, every muscle turning against him with surgical precision. Still *smell* the sheer, unfiltered panic as his body refused to obey anything but the torment it was drowning in.

He clenched his jaw and shoved it down. He was safe. The trial was over. His people were here. That was what mattered.

The memory would fade from his nerves — eventually. The Fog would see to that, whether he liked it or not. But that lingering taste, the knowledge of what had been done? That wasn’t going anywhere. Just another piece of trauma to be shelved, right alongside all the others.

Jake exhaled, letting his head rest on his knees.

And yet, even with everything he was trying *not* to think about, one weird detail kept itching at the edge of his thoughts.

“Hey, Felix?” Jake’s voice cut through the quiet, still scratchy but steady. “Why would the Doctor tell me to say hi to you for him?”

Felix went rigid, his grin falling, replaced by a haunted vacancy that made Jake’s stomach twist. To one side, Jake felt David’s posture stiffen slightly with a nearly silent inhale.

Jake blinked. “What?” he asked cautiously. “What happened?”

Felix didn't answer. His breath hitched — almost a flinch — before he surged to his feet and stormed off into the darker edges of the camp, muttering something sharp and half-German under his breath. Meg and Leon watched him go; curiosity blended with sympathy clear in their eyes. Claudette chased after him, earning a heated string of words for her trouble that left her frozen at the treeline, helpless as he vanished into the woods.

Several nearby survivors who'd been lingering too close scattered in his wake, ducking behind trees and cover like startled animals, fleeing the direct fire of the oncoming warpath.

Jake started to rise, guilt sparking fresh adrenaline through his limbs — but David's hand clamped around his wrist and pulled him back down.

"What...? What did I do?"

"Let him go," David sighed softly. "Felix and the Doc... those two have history."

Jake stared after the direction Felix had gone, brow furrowed. "The fuck did the Doctor *do* to him?"

David shook his head, turning back to the fire, poking at the edge of the flames like they held better answers.

"He doesn't like to talk about it," he said finally. "And I'm not about to do it for him. We all got our issues here. Let's leave it at that."

A sudden *crash* rang out in the distance — something getting kicked over hard — and Jake winced, his nerves tightening in sympathy. Whatever had happened to Felix... it hadn't faded with the Fog. It was clearly still very raw.

David didn't look up. "Gotta say though," he muttered, flipping a smoldering branch. "If the Doc took time to stab at Felix before going after you... you're lucky you came back in the state you did."

Jake stared into the fire, watching the flames dance in silence as the distant echo of German curses was swallowed by the Fog. A heavy quiet settled over the group — unsettling in its stillness.

He'd thought the trial couldn't have been worse. Couldn't have hurt more. But now... now he wasn't so sure.

His nerves still trembled faintly beneath his skin. The air tasted sharp, gritty. His lungs stung when he drew a full breath. His bones felt hollowed out from the strain and shock, still aching in ways the Fog hadn't soothed yet — and might not for a while.

If *this* was lucky...

Then what the hell did *unlucky* look like?

His gaze drifted to the shadows where Felix had disappeared.

What the hell had *happened* between him and the Doctor?

Jake exhaled slowly, the fire's warmth doing little to chase the chill settling in his gut.

Hopefully, he'd never have to find out.

